

I've spent \$12M on ads. Here's what I learned.

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Executive Summary

After personally spending over \$12M on ads, Tim Luong argues the winning formula is relentless testing, ruthless scaling of winners, and continuous parallel testing — because hit-rate on ad messaging is only 1-in-5 to 1-in-10.

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Test a Lot and Think Like Your Avatar 0:00

- The foundational principle from \$12M in ad spend: **you just have to test a lot**
 - No shortcut or formula replaces raw volume of tests
- Put yourself in the shoes of your avatar (ideal customer)
 - Frame messaging from the customer's perspective, not the brand's
- Test messaging specifically — not just creatives or formats, but the core message being communicated

Squeeze Winners as Hard as Possible 0:00

- When you find a winning ad, extract every single ounce of performance from it
 - Scale budget aggressively on proven messaging
 - Don't move on prematurely — fully exhaust the winner's potential

Never Stop Testing While Scaling 0:15

- The most common mistake Tim sees: people squeeze a winner but stop producing new test ads in parallel
 - They ride the winner until it dies, then have nothing in the pipeline
 - Result: revenue collapses when the winning ad fatigues

The fix is to run both tracks simultaneously — scale what's working AND continuously feed new

messaging tests at the same time.



Why Volume Is Non-Negotiable 0:23

- Hit rate on ad messaging is extremely low: only **1-in-5 to 1-in-10 ads** actually land on messaging you can scale
 - This low success rate is the core reason high test volume is required
 - If you need 5–10 attempts to find one winner, you must always have tests running
- Practical implication: treat ad testing as an ongoing system, not a one-time project